



COMMUNICATION

ESTYLE

Today's Concepts, TOMORROW'S PHONES



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As far as technology is concerned, the future is always far away. Designers never live in the present moment. If they did, we would not be having smartphones in our hands. And now that we do, they are busy designing something else—phones that can be folded, phones that can be worn and so on.

We look at some such mind-blowing concept phones. Some are new while others were developed years ago, but continue to fascinate developers and user communities even now. Although you will want to pre-order many of these fantastic phones as soon as you read about these, you might have to wait because many are still no more than concepts, while others are going through the rigours of development.

Your content, only for your eyes

Phones of the future are expected to be as capable as desktop computers, and might

even be used for critical business transactions. So a greater level of security would be needed.

Some years ago, Dell developed a software based technology that overlays a distorted pixel based pattern across the screen. This on-demand security feature narrows the viewing angle, so that only the user can view the contents of the screen. Those viewing from behind or from the sides cannot. Already available on some Dell laptop models, this would be a nice feature to have on future phones, too.

A few months ago, NTT DoCoMo and Fujitsu unveiled a phone that can identify the user through iris recognition. This could be used to unlock the phone as well as to certify mobile payments without having to enter passwords in public.

Hanky-panky phones

With the growing popularity of organic light-emitting diodes (OLEDs), a technology that enables displays to be made of flexible, organic materials, the advent of graphene that promises a lot of disruptions in everything from displays to hardware, and continuous improvements in flexible electronics, we can expect to see phones that can be rolled up like paper or folded up like hankies.

The quest for flexible phones has been on for quite some time now. A few years ago, NEC Design came up with an interesting Tag Soft-Shell mobile phone, made of a rubbery, shape-memorising material, which enabled the phone to flex at the user's command.

Nokia 888 is another concept that combines a flexible touchscreen with liquid battery to ensure flexibility. A

Is Microsoft quietly building a phone for the future

Last July, in an interview with ZDNet's Mary Jo Foley, Microsoft chief executive officer, Satya Nadella said, "When I think about our Windows Phone, I want it to stand for something like Continuum. When I say, wow, that is an interesting approach where you can have a phone and that same phone, because of our universal platform with Continuum, can, in fact, be a desktop. That is not something any other phone operating system or device can do. And that is what I want our devices and device innovation to stand for." Although Microsoft has still not revealed any specific plans for its future phone, people are calling it Surface Phone.

When quizzed about this, Chris Capossela, chief marketing officer for Microsoft, remarked in a television interview in December 2015 that the phone would be a spiritual equivalent to Surface—whatever that means. With Panos Panay, the brains behind Surface, now heading Microsoft's mobile phone business too, rumours about Surface Phone have spiked. If and when it comes, it is believed that this phone will not look too different, as it will not take the form of a ring, a bracelet or glasses. It will be futuristic only in its functionality, as it will further Continuum's vision by making your phone a veritable computer. Apps that run on your Windows laptop will all work on the phone too, and you will be able to seamlessly alternate between your desktop and your phone, as you move in and out of your office.